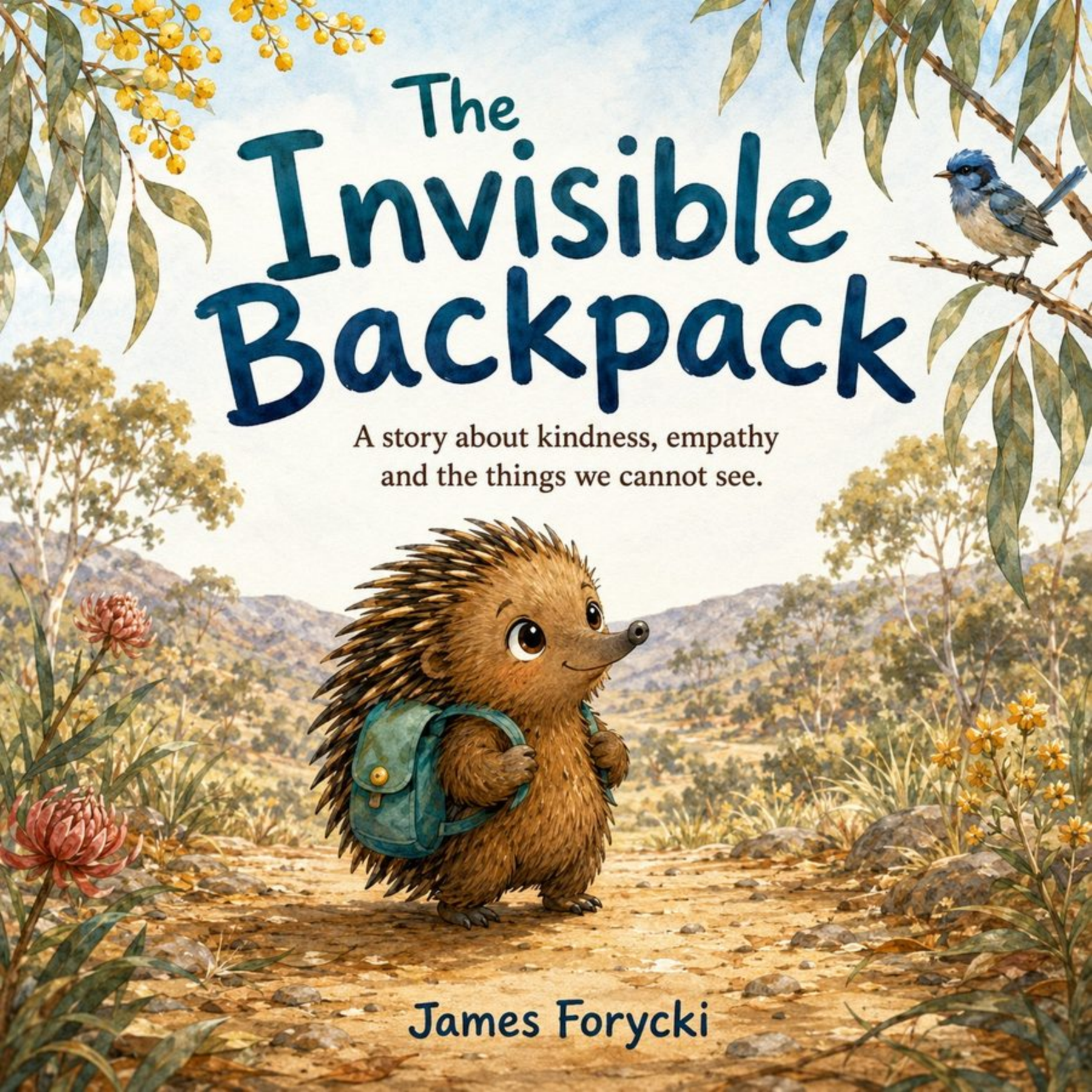




The Invisible Backpack

A story about kindness, empathy
and the things we cannot see.



James Forycki



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The Invisible Backpack

Written by James Forycki





For every little heart
carrying big feelings.

In a warm little forest
lived a tiny echidna named Pip.



Pip noticed things
others sometimes missed.



One morning,
all the animals walked
to the clearing.



Kangaroo bounced.
Koala wandered.
Wombat shuffled.
Birdie fluttered.



Then Pip noticed
something strange.



Everyone was
carrying a backpack.



Not a backpack
you could touch.



A whimsical illustration of a small brown hedgehog with a blue backpack standing on a dirt path in a forest. The hedgehog is looking up at a magical, swirling display of invisible backpacks. The display features four backpacks in different colors (yellow, blue, green, and purple) floating within colorful, ethereal clouds. The scene is decorated with various elements like stars, hearts, butterflies, and small animals (a squirrel, a mouse, and a bear) in matching colors. The background shows a tree with yellow blossoms on the left and more yellow flowers on the right.

These backpacks
were invisible.

Kangaroo's backpack
looked light.
She laughed and leaped.



Birdie's backpack looked tiny.
He sang sweet songs.



But Koala's backpack
looked very heavy.



A detailed illustration of a koala sitting on the ground at the base of a large gum tree. The koala is grey with large, fluffy ears and a black nose, looking down with a sad expression. It has its arms crossed over its chest. To its right is a small, blue camouflage-patterned backpack with a yellow button. The ground is covered in dry, brown leaves and twigs. In the background, there are more trees and a hazy landscape under a bright sky. The tree's trunk is thick and textured, with some yellow flowers hanging from its branches at the top of the frame.

Koala sat alone under the gum tree.
He did not climb.
He did not play.

A detailed illustration of a hedgehog and a koala in a natural setting. The hedgehog, on the left, is brown with a blue backpack and is looking towards the koala. The koala, on the right, is grey and sitting on the ground, looking back at the hedgehog. They are standing on a dirt path with rocks and small plants. In the background, there are trees and a hilly landscape under a bright sky. A large tree with yellow flowers is on the far left.

Pip asked softly,
'Are you okay, Koala?'

‘I think so,’ said Koala.
But his voice sounded small.



At lunch, Wombat dropped his berries.
They rolled into the dirt.



Pip helped pick them up,
one by one.



“Thank you,” whispered Wombat.

And just like that,
his backpack looked
a little lighter.



Pip blinked.

“Kindness makes backpacks
lighter,” he whispered
to himself.



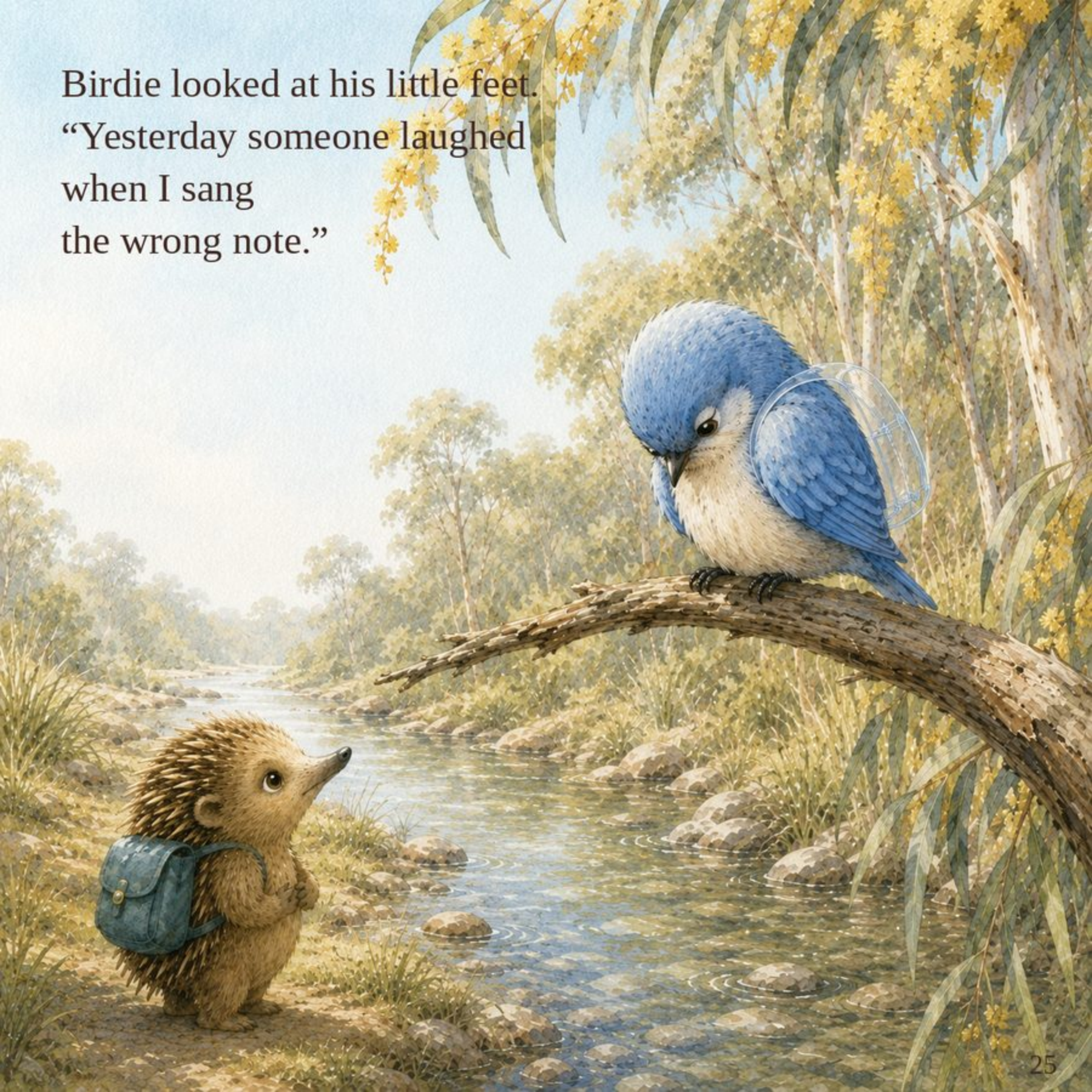
Near the river,
Birdie sat quietly
on a branch.
He was not singing.



“Why aren’t you singing today?” asked Pip.



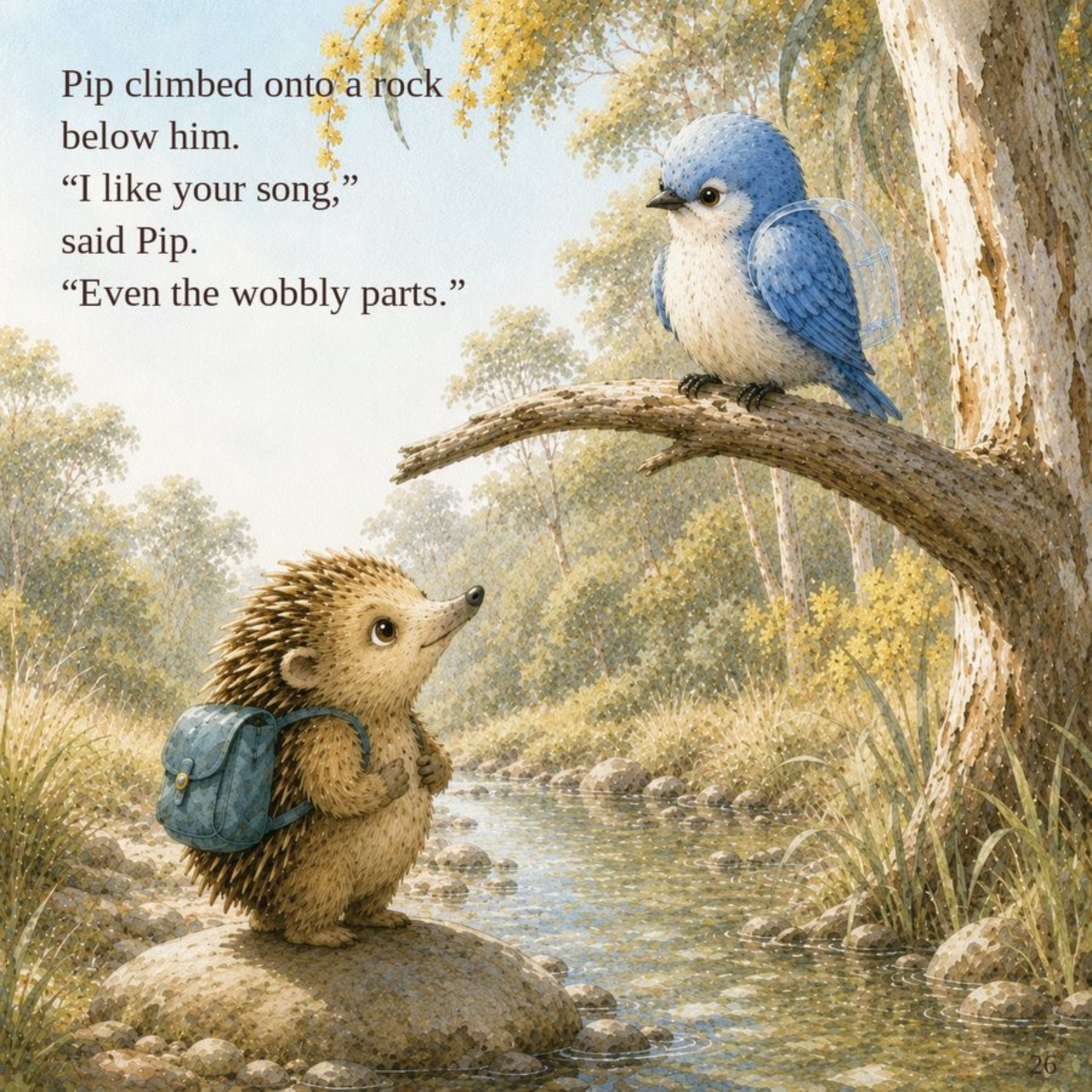
Birdie looked at his little feet.
“Yesterday someone laughed
when I sang
the wrong note.”



Pip climbed onto a rock
below him.

“I like your song,”
said Pip.

“Even the wobbly parts.”



Birdie looked surprised.
Then he sang
one tiny note.
Tweet.



Pip felt something warm
grow inside his chest.
Maybe helping
did not have to be big.



Then Pip saw Kangaroo.
She was bouncing
higher than anyone.
Boing.
Boing.
Boing.



Everyone clapped.
“You’re amazing!” called Birdie.
“You’re so brave!” said Wombat.
Kangaroo’s smile
was a little too bright.



For Parents & Teachers

Discussion & Connection

- What is something you might keep in an invisible backpack?
- How can you tell if someone's backpack is heavy?
- What can you do to help someone feel lighter?
- How did Pip help his friends?
- When do you feel most like Pip?



Small acts of kindness can make a big difference.





We may not see
what someone is carrying,
but we can always
choose to be kind.